THE BULLOCK PRESIDENCY

BOOK TWO: MR. PRESIDENT

Chapter 12 — "Day One"

Monday, January 6, 2025 – Tuesday, January 21, 2025

COLD OPEN — "THE ROTUNDA"

MONTAGE — JANUARY 5 TO JANUARY 20, 2025

— SUNDAY, JANUARY 5, 2025. Sunrise Hill. The President-elect turns thirty-three. His birthday cake, designed by Victoria, is shaped like the Resolute Desk. Emma has added fondant footnotes.

— MONDAY, JANUARY 6, 1:00 PM EST. The House chamber. Four years to the day after the attack on the Capitol, a joint session of Congress meets to count the electoral votes. Presiding, as President of the Senate: VICE PRESIDENT KAMALA HARRIS (60). She reads the certificates state by state. Georgia: sixteen votes, signed in flowing cursive by an elector named Odessa Grant Smilley. When she announces the total, "Marc-Anthony Bullock of the State of California has received three hundred fifty-nine votes," the chamber rises. Democrats and Republicans alike.

— TUESDAY, JANUARY 7. Los Angeles. Hurricane-force Santa Ana winds. Fire erupts in the Pacific Palisades, and that evening in Altadena, the foothill town that was one of the first places in Southern California where Black families could buy homes. By morning, entire neighborhoods are gone.

— WEDNESDAY, JANUARY 8, 6:14 AM PST. Altadena. Smoke. Ash falling like snow. The President-elect, in a respirator and a fire department jacket, standing in the ruins of a block on Lake Avenue with a Black grandmother who has just learned her house of fifty-one years is gone. No cameras. Dante made sure. She holds his hand and tells him her husband built the back porch himself in 1974. Marc writes it down in a notebook.

— THURSDAY, JANUARY 9. The Washington National Cathedral. The state funeral of the thirty-ninth President, Jimmy Carter, who died December twenty-ninth at a hundred years old. Five Presidents, past and future, in the front pews. The President-elect sits beside Esther, three rows behind Joe Biden and Donald Trump.

— SUNDAY, JANUARY 19. In Gaza, the first phase of a ceasefire between Israel and Hamas takes effect after fifteen months of war. The first three hostages come home. The President-elect issues a one-line statement: "Every hostage home. Every civilian protected. We start tomorrow."

— Weather forecasters warn that Inauguration Day in Washington will be the coldest in forty years. Officials move the ceremony indoors, to the Capitol Rotunda, for the first time since 1985.

INT. U.S. CAPITOL — THE ROTUNDA — WASHINGTON, D.C. — DAY

SUPER: MONDAY, JANUARY 20, 2025 — INAUGURATION DAY — 11:59 AM EST

SUPER: 22°F OUTSIDE

Beneath the dome. Beneath "The Apotheosis of Washington," the fresco that Cornelius Smilley stopped to look at on the morning of January 3, 2023. Six hundred people where a million would have stood outside. Flags at half-staff for President Carter. Statues of Presidents ringing the room: Washington, Jefferson, Lincoln, Grant, Eisenhower, Reagan.

Every person from this story is here. In the front rows: Victor (78) and Joan (76). Natasha (53) and Robert (55). Elxa (34), Grace (30). Gloria Baker (58). Odessa Smilley (96) in her wheelchair at the end of the first row, in a white hat the size of a satellite dish; the Architect of the Capitol personally approved the brim. Beside her, Cornelius (66), Lorraine (63), Neil (40), and Simone (37), Secretary of Homeland Security-designate, confirmation vote scheduled for tomorrow morning. Further back: Patti Grove (60), Arianna (32), Tayia (32), Tyler (33). And, in a seat the President-elect personally assigned, in a Navy veteran's cap he has been politely asked to remove and has respectfully declined to: Roy Chapman (67), with Mae (65).

In the second row, President Joe Biden (82) and the First Lady. Vice President Harris and the Second Gentleman. Former Presidents. And Donald Trump (78), who came. Nobody was sure he would.

On the platform at the center of the Rotunda: CHIEF JUSTICE JOHN ROBERTS (69), in his robe. Beside him, holding a worn black family Bible with a cracked spine, its pages swollen from a hundred and twenty years of births and deaths written inside the front cover: Esther Bullock (32). It is Odessa Smilley's Bible. Josiah's name is in it. Thaddeus's name is in it. Emma's and Victoria's names are in it, in Odessa's handwriting, added in 2012 when no one else in the family would say them out loud.

Beside Esther, Emma and Victoria (12), in matching navy coats. And Lyric Baker (10), holding hands with her father.

Marc-Anthony Bullock (33) places his left hand on the Bible. Raises his right.

CHIEF JUSTICE ROBERTS
Please raise your right hand and repeat after me. I, Marc-Anthony Bullock, do solemnly swear...

MARC
I, Marc-Anthony Bullock, do solemnly swear...

CHIEF JUSTICE ROBERTS
...that I will faithfully execute the office of President of the United States...

MARC
...that I will faithfully execute the office of President of the United States...

CHIEF JUSTICE ROBERTS
...and will to the best of my ability, preserve, protect, and defend the Constitution of the United States.

MARC
...and will to the best of my ability, preserve, protect, and defend the Constitution of the United States.

(beat)
So help me God.

SUPER: 12:02 PM EST — MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK SWORN IN AS THE 47TH PRESIDENT OF THE UNITED STATES

CHIEF JUSTICE ROBERTS
Congratulations, Mr. President.

The Rotunda erupts. A twenty-one-gun salute booms outside on the frozen Mall, muffled by the stone. In the first row, Odessa has both hands pressed over her heart.

Minutes earlier, Amond Baker (32) was sworn in as the fiftieth Vice President by JUSTICE KETANJI BROWN JACKSON (54), on his mother's Bible, the one Gloria Baker has kept on her nightstand since 1989. Lyric held it.

The inaugural address is eighteen minutes long. Its most quoted line, which by nightfall is printed on t-shirts in four languages:

MARC (ON SCREEN)
Two hundred and thirty-six years ago, the Founders wrote a Constitution so their grandchildren could change it. Last month, we did. Not because we're smarter than they were. Because we're their grandchildren.

(beat)
A little girl asked me why I couldn't fix it. She's standing right behind me. Today

I start answering her.

— 3:10 PM EST. The inaugural parade, moved indoors to Capital One Arena. Twenty thousand people. Marching bands from Dorsey High School in Los Angeles, Morehouse College, and the University of Texas. A contingent of Puerto Rican bomba drummers. A float from Detroit with both Coney Island restaurants on it, side by side.

— 4:41 PM EST. The President steps out of the presidential limousine on Pennsylvania Avenue for a block, against the Secret Service's wishes. Agent Okonjo (49) walks beside him with a face like a closed door.

AGENT OKONJO
Mr. President, it's twenty degrees.

MARC
Agent Okonjo, I'm from Los Angeles. I've never been this cold in my life. I'm walking one block so I can tell my grandkids I did.

AGENT OKONJO
One block, sir.

MARC
One block.

He walks two.

INT. THE WHITE HOUSE — THE OVAL OFFICE — NIGHT

SUPER: MONDAY, JANUARY 20, 2025 — 8:46 PM EST

His first time in this room as its occupant. The Resolute Desk, carved from the timbers of a British ship. New drapes: navy, Esther's choice. On the wall where every President hangs a portrait of a predecessor he admires: Abraham Lincoln and, newly placed, a framed photograph of Shirley Chisholm announcing her 1972 campaign. On the credenza: family photos. And, in a small frame, the twins' card: "We are just your granddaughters. Footnote: This is true." Cornelius sent it to him as a gift this morning. "Return it when you leave office," the note said. "Eight years. I'll be waiting."

The President, in his inaugural suit, tie loosened, sits at the desk for the first time. Before the balls. Before anything. ELXA BULLOCK (34), White House Chief of Staff, stands across the desk with a leather folder. BENJAMIN OSEI (34), White House Counsel, beside her.

ELXA
You have to be at the first ball at nine-thirty.

MARC
I know.

ELXA
You said you'd sign one order tonight. One.

MARC
One.

Osei opens the folder. A single document. "EXECUTIVE ORDER — ETHICS COMMITMENTS BY EXECUTIVE BRANCH PERSONNEL."

OSEI
The Clean Government Order, Mr. President. Ethics pledge for every appointee. A lobbying ban. A two-year cooling-off period. And a ban on individual stock trading by every senior official of the executive branch, including the President and the Vice President.

MARC
Including me.

OSEI
Including you, sir. Your holdings are already in the blind trust. This puts it in writing.

MARC
Good. First thing I sign as President is a rule that applies to me.

He picks up a pen. Signs. "Marc-Anthony Bullock." And then, very small, beside it, a bluebird.

OSEI
Sir, you can't —

MARC
Is there a rule?

OSEI
(sighing)
...I'll check, Mr. President.

ELXA
Executive Order 14148. Your first one. Tomorrow, eleven more.

MARC
Twelve.

ELXA
The plan was eleven.

MARC
The plan changed in Altadena.

SUPER: 8:49 PM EST — EXECUTIVE ORDER 14148: "ETHICS COMMITMENTS BY EXECUTIVE BRANCH PERSONNEL"

ACT ONE — "THE FIRST MORNING"

INT. THE WHITE HOUSE — SECOND FLOOR RESIDENCE — MASTER BEDROOM — DAWN

SUPER: TUESDAY, JANUARY 21, 2025 — 5:52 AM EST

SUPER: THE FIRST FULL DAY

Gray winter light through tall windows. The President of the United States is asleep. Five inaugural balls. He danced with his wife at all five and with his daughters at three, and with Odessa Smilley once, very slowly, at the Black Inaugural Ball at the Smithsonian's National Museum of African American History and Culture, where she told him, "Don't you dare spin me, I'm ninety-six."

Esther asleep beside him.

The door creaks open. A twelve-year-old head appears. VICTORIA BULLOCK, in pajamas, hair wrapped, eyes enormous.

VICTORIA
(whispering)
Daddy.

Nothing.

VICTORIA
Daddy. DADDY.

MARC
(eyes closed)
Mmm.

VICTORIA
There's a man outside our door in a suit.

MARC
That's Agent Hollis. He's Secret Service. He's always going to be outside the door.

VICTORIA
He said "Good morning, Miss Bullock." He called me MISS BULLOCK.

MARC
You're the President's daughter now. Everybody's going to call you Miss Bullock.

Victoria absorbs this. Then:

VICTORIA
There's a bowling alley.

Marc opens one eye.

VICTORIA
In the BASEMENT. Emma found a map. There's a bowling alley, and a movie theater, and a flower shop, and a chocolate shop, and a dentist. A DENTIST. In our HOUSE.

MARC
Vic, it's six in the morning.

VICTORIA
Emma's already down there. She's making a spreadsheet of the rooms. There are a hundred and thirty-two.

Esther, still face-down in her pillow:

ESTHER
Victoria Bullock, you will not bowl in the White House before seven o'clock in the morning.

VICTORIA
Is that a rule?

ESTHER
It's a rule now.

Victoria considers this, then sprints away. Marc lies back and stares at the ceiling of the President's bedroom.

MARC
Esther.

ESTHER
Mm.

MARC
I'm the President.

ESTHER
I know, baby. You said it eleven times last night.

MARC
I'm going to say it a twelfth time.

ESTHER
Go sign your orders, Mr. President.

INT. THE WHITE HOUSE — THE OVAL OFFICE — MORNING

SUPER: 7:31 AM EST

The first President's Daily Brief. The most secret document in the government, delivered every morning. Around the coffee table: the President, Vice President Amond Baker (32), Chief of Staff Elxa Bullock, and National Security Advisor MARA LINDGREN (37), Nordic-blonde, Minnesota-calm, a former deputy national security adviser who has briefed three Presidents and has never once seen one sit on the floor.

The President is sitting on the floor, cross-legged, against the couch, with the leather-bound PDB open on the coffee table.

MARA
Mr. President, there are chairs.

MARC
I think better on the floor.

AMOND
He's done this since he was four. You'll get used to it.

MARA
(beat; she sits on the edge of the couch)
Page one. Gaza. Day three of the ceasefire. Phase one is holding. Three hostages released Sunday. Four more expected Saturday. The next ninety-six hours are the most fragile.

MARC
And the Peace Initiative?

MARA
Secretary Asante-Brooks was confirmed last night, eighty-one to seventeen. She's already spoken with Doha and Cairo. She'd like to fly to the region Thursday.

MARC
Tell her yes.

MARA
Page two. Ukraine. The front is largely static, heavy drone warfare, winter conditions. Kyiv has asked for a call today.

MARC
Today.

MARA
Page three.

She turns the page. Hesitates.

MARA
China. Taiwan Strait. PLA naval activity elevated since the election. Not unusual for a transition period. But the pattern is... studious. They're watching what you do first.

Marc looks at the page for a long moment.

MARC
Then let's give them something to watch.

He closes the PDB. Hands it back to Mara. She looks at him, an assessment, the way a coach watches a rookie take the first snap.

MARA
Sir, most Presidents ask follow-up questions on their first morning.

MARC
I've got about four hundred. I'm saving them for you every morning for four years. You're going to hate me.

MARA
...I don't think I will, Mr. President.

INT. WASHINGTON NATIONAL CATHEDRAL — NAVE — MORNING

SUPER: 10:02 AM EST

The National Prayer Service, a tradition since George Washington. The nave of the Gothic cathedral where, twelve days ago, the country buried Jimmy Carter. Clergy of every faith: a rabbi, an imam, a Catholic cardinal, a Hindu priest, a Buddhist teacher, a Lakota spiritual leader invited by Interior Secretary-designate Winona Redcloud.

And, at the request of the President, delivering the final benediction from the Canterbury Pulpit, in a black clerical robe: REV. DR. CALVIN HOLLOWAY (70), pastor of Greater Mount Calvary Baptist Church of Atlanta.

REV. HOLLOWAY
Lord, bless this young President. Thirty-three years old. The same age as your Son when he finished his work on Earth.

(a murmur in the cathedral)
Give him the patience of the old and keep in him the boldness of the young. And Lord, when he stands on the furniture, and he will stand on the furniture, let him be standing for somebody who can't.

In the front pew, Odessa Smilley says "Amen" out loud, alone. Then the whole cathedral follows.

ACT TWO — "THE ORDERS"

INT. ABC NEWS — SPECIAL COVERAGE — NEW YORK — AFTERNOON

SUPER: TUESDAY, JANUARY 21, 2025 — 1:58 PM EST

DAVID MUIR (51) at the anchor desk.

DAVID MUIR
Good afternoon. On his first full day in office, President Bullock is about to sign a series of executive orders in the Oval Office, a dozen, the White House says, covering everything from immigration to clean energy to the Los Angeles wildfires. Last night, he signed one: an ethics order that bans senior officials in his administration, including himself, from trading individual stocks. We go live to the Oval Office.

CHYRON: LIVE: PRESIDENT BULLOCK SIGNS EXECUTIVE ORDERS ON FIRST FULL DAY

INT. THE WHITE HOUSE — THE OVAL OFFICE — AFTERNOON

SUPER: 2:01 PM EST

The Oval Office as no one has seen it. Packed. The press pool along the back wall: cameras, boom mics, forty reporters. Arrayed around the room: Cabinet members, confirmed and not yet confirmed, who will be called forward one at a time. Patti Grove (60), Counselor to the President, standing in the corner with her arms crossed, watching like a stage manager on opening night.

The President, at the Resolute Desk.

Beside him, in a navy dress and the gold tiara she has been told forty times she can't wear to the White House and has worn anyway: LYRIC BAKER (10). Fifth grade, until Monday at Sidwell Friends. In front of her on the desk: a wooden box holding twelve pens. Each is engraved: "THE PRESIDENT — JANUARY 21, 2025 — LET'S FIX IT."

Her job: hand him a pen for each signature, and then give each pen to the person it belongs to. She practiced last night in the Naval Observatory kitchen with her father, using chopsticks.

At her feet, in a tiny bow tie, sitting perfectly still because he was told, BET the dog.

MARC
Good afternoon, everybody. Thanks for squeezing in. It's a small room. I didn't realize how small until I tried to fit my whole Cabinet in it.

(laughter)
Last night, I signed one order. It said that everyone who works for me, starting with me, follows the rules. Today, we start fixing the rules.

(beat)
I want to be honest about something before I sign anything. An executive order is not a law. It's a President telling his own government what to do. It's fast, and it's limited, and the next President can undo every one of these with a pen of their own. The laws come from Congress. I'll be sending Congress a lot of them. These orders are bridges. Congress builds the roads.

(beat)
And the young lady with the tiara is in charge of pens. Don't argue with her. I don't.

Laughter. Lyric, solemn as a judge, lifts the first pen from the box.

MONTAGE — THE SIGNINGS — 2:06 PM TO 3:12 PM EST

Each order: the President reads its name aloud, says a few words, signs, holds it up for the cameras. Lyric hands the pen to the person called forward. A graphic for each.

SUPER: EXECUTIVE ORDER 14149 — 2:06 PM

GRAPHIC — "SECURING AN ORDERLY, SECURE, AND LEGAL IMMIGRATION SYSTEM"

MARC
Number one today. Immigration. I said it in the Coliseum and I'll say it here. Orderly. Secure. Legal. This order surges immigration judges and asylum officers to clear a backlog of more than three million cases. It opens lawful pathways, renews protected status, protects DACA recipients, ends family detention, and modernizes every port of entry. It does not, and cannot, make every immigrant legal. Only Congress can do that. But it starts.

He signs. Holds it up.

MARC
Secretary Smilley.

SIMONE SMILLEY (37) steps forward. Confirmed this morning, seventy-four to twenty-five, the most bipartisan Cabinet confirmation since 2009, sworn in at 11:40 AM by her brother Neil, holding her grandmother's Bible. Lyric hands her the pen. Simone holds it like it might burn.

SIMONE
(quietly, to Marc)
Orderly. Secure. Legal.

MARC
(quietly)
Five times a sentence. Your daddy's rule.

SUPER: EXECUTIVE ORDER 14150 — 2:11 PM

GRAPHIC — "ESTABLISHING THE 100-DAY PEACE INITIATIVE"

MARC
Number two. Peace. Ukraine and Russia. Israel and the Palestinians, building on the ceasefire that began Sunday: every hostage home, every civilian protected. The Taiwan Strait. Special envoys named today. Secretary Asante-Brooks leaves for the Middle East Thursday.

Lyric hands the pen to SECRETARY OF STATE NALEDI ASANTE-BROOKS (36). She bows slightly to Lyric. Lyric bows back.

SUPER: EXECUTIVE ORDER 14151 — 2:15 PM

GRAPHIC — "ESTABLISHING THE NORTH AMERICAN PARTNERSHIP COMMISSION"

MARC
Number three. A commission to begin talks with our neighbors, Canada and Mexico, on a closer partnership. Economic. Cultural. Human. Someday, maybe, a union. This order doesn't create anything but a conversation. That's how every good thing starts.

Lyric hands the pen to U.S. Trade Representative-designate OMAR HADDAD (35), who has not been confirmed yet and is technically here as "a guest." He takes the pen and puts it in his breast pocket over his heart.

SUPER: EXECUTIVE ORDER 14152 — 2:19 PM

GRAPHIC — "PREPARING THE AMERICAN SOVEREIGN FUND"

MARC
Number four. The American Sovereign Fund. Everybody said it was a fantasy. This order tells the Treasury Department to find out exactly what we own. Every acre. Every mineral right. Every patent our tax dollars paid for. Every slice of the airwaves. Ninety days. Then we send Congress the blueprint.

Lyric hands the pen to Treasury Secretary-designate JULIAN PARK (37), hearing tomorrow, who looks at it and says, "This is the most expensive pen I'll ever hold." Marc: "Write something worth it."

SUPER: EXECUTIVE ORDER 14153 — 2:24 PM

GRAPHIC — "LOWERING THE COST OF LIFE-SAVING MEDICINES"

Pen to HHS Secretary-designate DR. JONAH FELD (37).

SUPER: EXECUTIVE ORDER 14154 — 2:28 PM

GRAPHIC — "TEN MILLION HOMES: EXPANDING HOUSING ON FEDERAL LAND"

Pen to HUD Secretary-designate DARNELL PRICE (35).

MARC
Darnell, how many homes have you built?

DARNELL
Eleven thousand, Mr. President.

MARC
Nine million nine hundred and eighty-nine thousand to go. Starting today.

SUPER: EXECUTIVE ORDER 14155 — 2:33 PM

GRAPHIC — "EVERY LEAD PIPE: REPLACING LEAD SERVICE LINES WITHIN FOUR YEARS"

MARC
Number seven. In 2015, I broke a few rules in Flint. I sent crews to replace pipes while the permits were still "under review." I paid the fines. I'd do it again. As President, I don't have to break the rules anymore. Congress already gave us fifteen billion dollars in 2021 to replace lead pipes. This order says: use it. Every lead pipe in America, gone, in four years. Flint goes first.

From the back of the room, a woman in a "FLINT STRONG" sweatshirt, an invited guest, a mother whose son was poisoned in 2014, starts crying openly. Lyric walks the pen across the Oval Office and hands it to her instead of to the EPA Administrator-designate. Nobody told her to. Kai Mahoe, beside the woman, nods.

SUPER: EXECUTIVE ORDER 14156 — 2:39 PM

GRAPHIC — "ACCELERATING AMERICA'S CLEAN ENERGY FUTURE"

Pen to Energy Secretary-designate DR. THEO NAKAMURA (34), who drops it, picks it up, and says "Sorry, I'm a physicist." The press pool laughs.

SUPER: EXECUTIVE ORDER 14157 — 2:44 PM

GRAPHIC — "ESTABLISHING THE NATIONAL COUNCIL ON POLITICAL VIOLENCE AND DOMESTIC PEACE"

MARC
Number nine. Last year somebody tried to kill a candidate for President in Butler, Pennsylvania. Two months later, somebody tried again in Florida. A firefighter named Corey Comperatore died protecting his family. I called President Trump both times. We disagreed about almost everything. We agreed about that.

(beat)
This order creates a council to study and stop political violence in America. Democrats and Republicans. Law enforcement and clergy. And it starts with a simple rule for this White House: we don't call

our opponents enemies.

He signs. Lyric hands the pen to Attorney General-designate Arianna Cummings (32), whose confirmation vote is Thursday.

SUPER: EXECUTIVE ORDER 14158 — 2:49 PM

GRAPHIC — "NO VETERAN WAITS: ESTABLISHING MAXIMUM WAIT-TIME STANDARDS FOR VETERANS' CARE"

VA Secretary-designate ANDRE "DRE" COLEMAN (36) walks forward on his prosthetics. Lyric meets him halfway with the pen. He bends, carefully, to take it from her.

DRE
Thank you, ma'am.

LYRIC
You're welcome, sir. Thank you for your service.

Dre has to look at the ceiling for a second.

SUPER: EXECUTIVE ORDER 14159 — 2:54 PM

GRAPHIC — "ESTABLISHING THE PUERTO RICO EQUALITY TASK FORCE"

Pen to U.N. Ambassador-designate RAFAEL ORTIZ-RIVERA (32), born in San Juan. He holds it up to a camera and says something in Spanish that the pool reporters write down: "Para La Perla."

Then a pause. The President puts down his pen. The room quiets.

MARC
The last one wasn't in the plan.

(beat)
Two weeks ago, my hometown burned. The Palisades. Altadena. Altadena is one of the first places in Los Angeles where Black families could buy a home, when nobody else would sell to them. Teachers. Nurses. Jazz musicians. Grandmothers. Generations of them. Thousands of homes gone in one night.

(beat)
On January eighth, I stood on Lake Avenue with a woman named Mrs. Ernestine Powell. She's seventy-nine. Her house is gone. Her husband built the back porch in 1974. She asked me one question. "Baby, are we coming back?"

He holds up a document.

MARC
Executive Order 14160. The Los Angeles Wildfire Recovery and Rebuilding Order. Every federal agency, every resource, every dollar that FEMA has authority to spend. A federal coordinator in Altadena by Friday. A guarantee that no family loses their land because they're underinsured. And a promise to send Congress emergency funding within thirty days. Mrs. Powell, we're coming back.

He signs.

SUPER: EXECUTIVE ORDER 14160 — 3:03 PM

GRAPHIC — "LOS ANGELES WILDFIRE RECOVERY AND REBUILDING"

Lyric lifts the last pen from the box. She doesn't hand it to a Cabinet member. She walks across the Oval Office to the back row, where a small, elderly Black woman in a Sunday hat sits in a folding chair, flown in from Los Angeles this morning at the President's invitation: MRS. ERNESTINE POWELL (79).

Lyric hands her the pen. Mrs. Powell takes it. Looks at it. Looks at the ten-year-old in the tiara.

MRS. POWELL
Thank you, baby.

LYRIC
You're welcome. Uncle Marc says you have a porch.

MRS. POWELL
(tears running down her face)
I had a porch, baby.

LYRIC
Uncle Marc says you're going to have one again.

The Oval Office has gone completely silent. The press pool has stopped typing. Patti Grove, in the corner, has turned to face the wall.

The President stands.

MARC
Thirteen orders in two days. Twelve today. Now the real work starts. Thank you, everybody.

A reporter in the back calls out.

PRESS POOL REPORTER
Mr. President! Texas and Louisiana say they'll sue over the immigration order. Your response?

MARC
They should. That's how it works. They'll sue, and a judge will decide, and if I'm wrong, I'll fix it. If I'm right, I'll send Congress a bill that makes it permanent. Either way, nobody's breaking any rules in this building.

(beat, a grin)
Except the bluebird. Ben's still checking.

Laughter. White House Counsel Ben Osei, by the door, puts his face in his hand.

SUPER: 3:12 PM EST — 12 EXECUTIVE ORDERS SIGNED (EO 14149–14160), PLUS EO 14148 (JAN 20)

ACT THREE — "THE AFTERNOON"

INT. THE WHITE HOUSE — THE OVAL OFFICE — AFTERNOON

SUPER: 3:41 PM EST

The press is gone. The pens are gone. The Oval Office is almost empty. The President at the Resolute Desk with a phone. Mara Lindgren and Secretary Asante-Brooks on the couches. Calls with foreign leaders. We hear only his side.

MARC
(into phone)
Madam President. Buenas tardes. Thank you for taking my call.

(listens)
Yes. Omar Haddad will lead it. He's from Dearborn. His family came from Lebanon. He knows what it's like to be a neighbor.

(listens; laughs)
No, ma'am, I'm not going to say "union" yet. My father-in-law says I'm not allowed to say "union" south of Virginia.

Secretary Asante-Brooks smiles into her coffee.

SUPER: 3:41 PM — CALL WITH PRESIDENT CLAUDIA SHEINBAUM OF MEXICO

SUPER: 4:02 PM — CALL WITH PRIME MINISTER JUSTIN TRUDEAU OF CANADA

SUPER: 4:20 PM — CALL WITH PRESIDENT VOLODYMYR ZELENSKYY OF UKRAINE

At 4:20 PM, exactly, as the White House operator connects Kyiv, Elxa, in the doorway, notices the time, then notices the President noticing the time.

ELXA
(mouthing)
Don't.

MARC
(mouthing back, innocent)
I didn't schedule it.

ELXA
(mouthing)
You absolutely scheduled it.

INT. THE WHITE HOUSE — JAMES S. BRADY PRESS BRIEFING ROOM — AFTERNOON

SUPER: 4:47 PM EST

Forty-nine blue seats, every one taken. Reporters standing in the aisles. The podium with the White House seal. Behind it, the blue curtain, the oval window.

From the door at the side of the stage: White House Press Secretary GRACE BULLOCK (30). Navy suit. A binder. Her brother's sense of timing.

She steps to the podium. Looks out at the room.

GRACE
Good afternoon. Before we start, I'd like to make an announcement.

(beat)
I still pay eight dollars a month for Twitter verification. I'm going to continue to pay it, personally, out of my own salary. It's not a government expense. Please don't ask me about it again.

The briefing room erupts in laughter. Even the veteran reporters.

GRACE
Now. The President signed twelve executive orders this afternoon, on top of last night's ethics order. I'll take your questions. AP.

AP REPORTER
Grace, the immigration order. The President has said one hundred percent legal immigration. This order doesn't do that. Isn't that a broken promise on day two?

GRACE
It's day two. The President said in the Oval Office: an order is a bridge, Congress builds the road. The road is the Orderly, Secure, Legal Immigration Act, and it'll be sent to Capitol Hill within sixty days. Secretary Smilley will testify on it personally. Next. Fox.

FOX REPORTER
Grace, the North American Partnership Commission. Many Americans are worried this is the first step toward erasing the border with Mexico. What do you say to them?

GRACE
I'd say: read it. It's eleven pages. It creates a commission. Commissions talk. If the commission ever proposes anything that changes our border, Congress votes on it, and the American people see every word first. Nobody's erasing anything. We're starting a conversation with the two countries we share a continent with. Next. Reuters.

REUTERS REPORTER
The President is thirty-three. His Chief of Staff is his sister. You're his sister. His Communications Director was his co-star. His Secretary of Homeland Security is his sister-in-law. Is this a government, or a family business?

A pause in the room. This is the question everyone wanted asked.

Grace looks at the reporter for a long moment. Then she smiles. It's exactly her brother's smile.

GRACE
That's a fair question. And I'll give you a fair answer.

(beat)
Elxa ran the operations of a campaign that won three hundred and fifty-nine electoral votes and Texas. Simone Smilley was confirmed this morning by seventy-four senators, including thirty-one Republicans. Tayia Boyd has run communications for a campaign that reached more people than any in history. And I'm here because I've been answering questions about my brother since I was nine years old.

(beat)
Every one of us will be judged by our work. If we fail, you'll be the first to

tell everybody, and you should. But I'd ask you one thing. Wait until we've had a full week.

(beat)
Next. CNN.

> **Twitter · @GraceBullock**
>
> First briefing done. I'd like to thank the Reuters reporter for the best question of the day. I'd also like to thank my brother for teaching me to answer it.
>
> **801K Retweets · 6.2M Likes · 5:31 PM EST**

MONTAGE — REACTIONS — JANUARY 21, 2025

— 3:30 PM EST. The Texas Attorney General files suit in federal court in Texas challenging Executive Order 14149, the immigration order. Louisiana and Florida join within the hour.

— 4:15 PM EST. Speaker Mike Johnson, in a hallway gaggle, says House Republicans will "carefully review" the orders, calls the North American commission "a nonstarter for my conference," and says he's "open" to working with the President on the stock-trading ban and on veterans' care.

— 5:02 PM EST. Speaker Hakeem Jeffries (54), elected January 3 by the new Democratic majority, at a press conference says the House will take up the Congressional Stock Trading Ban "within weeks."

— 6:11 PM EST. Former President Trump posts that the President's immigration order is "the beginning of the end of our border," adding that he looks forward to their dinner in February, where he'll "tell him so to his face."

— 6:40 PM EST. In Flint, Michigan, a crowd gathers outside City Hall holding signs that read "FLINT GOES FIRST."

— 7:05 PM EST. In Altadena, on Lake Avenue, in front of a burned-out lot, a hand-painted sign on a chain-link fence: "WE'RE COMING BACK — 14160."

> **Twitter · #DayOne**
>
> Trending #1 Worldwide · 9.1M Tweets

> **Twitter · #LyricHandsThePens**
>
> Trending #2 Worldwide · 4.4M Tweets

> **Twitter · #14160**

Trending #3 in United States · 1.2M Tweets

Twitter · @TheBullpenDaily

13 EXECUTIVE ORDERS. LYRIC HANDED THE FLINT PEN TO A FLINT MOM. SHE HANDED THE LAST PEN TO MRS. POWELL FROM ALTADENA. "UNCLE MARC SAYS YOU'RE GOING TO HAVE A PORCH AGAIN." I'M NOT OKAY AND I'M NOT GOING TO BE OKAY.

1.2M Retweets · 8.4M Likes

Twitter · @PattiGrove

Day one. Thirteen orders. Zero rules broken. One bluebird, legal status pending. I turned to face the wall during the Altadena pen. I'd like that noted as "strategic."

401K Retweets · 3.2M Likes

Twitter · @RoyChapmanHouston

My son works in the White House. Today he stood in the Oval Office. He called me after. He said "Daddy, a ten-year-old ran the whole thing." I believe it.

1.1M Retweets · 7.8M Likes

Twitter · @FlintMom2014

The President's goddaughter walked across the Oval Office and handed ME the pen for the lead pipe order. Ten years. TEN YEARS. My son is 17 now. Flint goes first.

2.1M Retweets · 14.2M Likes

Twitter · @AltadenaRebuilds

Mrs. Ernestine Powell is our neighbor. She's 79. She was at the White House today. She has the pen. We're coming back.

901K Retweets · 6.8M Likes

Twitter · @BorderHawk_AZ

Day two and he's already opening the floodgates. "Orderly, secure, legal" is a slogan. Watch the numbers.

41K Retweets · 188K Likes

Twitter · @BorderHawk_AZ's replies

@SimoneSmilley: "I'm watching the numbers too. Every day. Starting this morning. Hold me to it."

302K Likes

Twitter · @ConstitutionCarl

13 executive orders, and the President opened by telling the press an EO is not a law and the next President can undo it. I've never heard a President say that out loud. I'm cautiously impressed. Still watching.

211K Retweets · 1.6M Likes

Twitter · @ConstitutionCarl's replies

@ArizonaGrandpa: "Carl, I'm in Washington. I'm at the Hay-Adams. Burrito's on me. Get down here."

401K Likes

TikTok · @first.daughter.tour

[Fan account: a leaked iPhone video, filmed by a staffer, of two 12-year-old girls in pajamas bowling in the White House bowling alley at 6:58 AM, while a Secret Service agent in a suit keeps score] "the president's daughters bowled at 6:58am. their mom said not before 7. they started at 6:58."

61.4M views · 18.1M likes

Reddit · r/politics

"MEGATHREAD: President Bullock signs 12 executive orders on first full day, including immigration, Peace Initiative, North American Partnership Commission, Sovereign Fund prep, lead pipes, and LA wildfire recovery"

1.2M upvotes · 288,112 comments · Top comment: "He literally opened by explaining that executive orders aren't laws and can be undone. Then he handed the pens to a Flint mom and an Altadena grandmother. Then he said 'they should' when asked about lawsuits. I've never seen a President act like he actually respects the separation of powers on day one."

Reddit · r/neoliberal

"EO 14152 (Sovereign Fund prep) is the sleeper. 90-day asset inventory of every federal acre, patent, and spectrum band. Nobody's ever done this."

92K upvotes

ASSOCIATED PRESS

Bullock signs 12 executive orders on first full day, launching immigration overhaul, peace push, and LA fire recovery; Texas sues within hours

THE NEW YORK TIMES

On Day One, a President Who Calls His Own Orders 'Bridges'

Bullock signs a dozen directives, then urges Congress to make them law, and invites the lawsuits.

THE WASHINGTON POST

What's in President Bullock's first 13 executive orders, and what they can and can't do

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL

Bullock's Sovereign-Fund Order Starts the Clock on a 90-Day Inventory of Federal Assets; Markets Shrug, Then Rally

POLITICO PLAYBOOK — WED, JAN 22

'Bridges, not roads': Bullock's day one strategy puts the ball in Congress's court

AXIOS

Day one by the numbers: 13 orders, 12 pens, 1 tiara, 3 lawsuits

FOX NEWS

Bullock's 'Orderly, Secure, Legal' Immigration Order Faces Immediate Legal Challenge From Texas, Louisiana, Florida

LOS ANGELES TIMES

'WE'RE COMING BACK': President's Wildfire Order Promises Federal Coordinator for Altadena by Friday

THE DETROIT FREE PRESS

FLINT GOES FIRST: Bullock Orders Every Lead Pipe in America Replaced in Four Years

EL NUEVO DÍA

"Para La Perla": Bullock Crea el Grupo de Trabajo para la Igualdad de Puerto Rico

THE HOLLYWOOD REPORTER

Grace Bullock's First Briefing: A Twitter Joke, a Tough Question, and the Answer That Went Viral

PEOPLE

Lyric Baker, 10, Hands the President His Pens, and the Last One to an Altadena Grandmother

TAG

INT. THE WHITE HOUSE — THE OVAL OFFICE — NIGHT

SUPER: TUESDAY, JANUARY 21, 2025 — 11:38 PM EST

The Oval Office at night. Lamps only. The Resolute Desk. The President alone, in his shirtsleeves. In front of him, a single envelope that has been sitting in the top drawer of the desk since noon yesterday, as tradition requires: a letter from the outgoing President to the incoming one. Addressed in a familiar hand: "To Marc."

He's been carrying it around in his head all day. He hasn't opened it.

He opens it now.

We don't see the letter. We see his face as he reads it. Once. Twice. A small laugh at something. Then, near the bottom, something that makes him put the letter down and press the heels of his hands against his eyes.

He folds it carefully. Puts it back in the envelope. Puts the envelope in the inside pocket of his suit jacket, hanging on the back of the chair.

Then he picks up the phone on the desk.

MARC
Hi. This is the President. Could you connect me to a number in Atlanta, please?

WHITE HOUSE OPERATOR (V.O.)
Of course, Mr. President.

A pause. Two rings.

INTERCUT — INT. SMILLEY HOUSE — CORNELIUS'S STUDY — ATLANTA — CONTINUOUS

The study. The Pettus Bridge lithograph. The safe, empty now. Cornelius (66), back home since this morning, in a robe, reading glasses, a legal pad. He picks up on the second ring.

CORNELIUS
Smilley.

WHITE HOUSE OPERATOR (V.O.)
Mr. Smilley, please hold for the President.

Cornelius sits up very straight in his chair. He has been on the receiving end of that sentence four times in his life. From Carter. From Clinton. From Obama. From Biden. Never like this.

MARC (V.O.)
Dad. It's me.

CORNELIUS
Mr. President.

MARC (V.O.)
You don't have to call me that.

CORNELIUS
I'll call you that every time you call me from that desk. You call me from anywhere else, I'll call you whatever I want.

Marc laughs.

CORNELIUS
I watched the signing. All of it. Your mother-in-law watched it twice.

MARC (V.O.)
What'd you think?

CORNELIUS
I think you said "orderly" four times in one sentence on the immigration order. I told you five.

MARC (V.O.)
I'll do better tomorrow.

CORNELIUS
And the Altadena one. That wasn't in the plan.

MARC (V.O.)
No.

CORNELIUS
That was the best one.

A pause.

CORNELIUS
You opened the letter.

MARC (V.O.)
(surprised)
How do you know?

CORNELIUS
Because it's eleven-forty at night and you called your father-in-law. A man doesn't call his father-in-law at eleven-forty unless he's just read something that made him need to hear an old voice.

Silence on the line.

MARC (V.O.)
...Yeah.

CORNELIUS
You don't have to tell me what it said.

MARC (V.O.)
I'm not going to.

CORNELIUS
Good. That's between Presidents.

Another silence. Comfortable, this time.

MARC (V.O.)
Dad. The girls start Sidwell on Monday. Victoria wants to know if there's bowling.

CORNELIUS
There isn't.

MARC (V.O.)
She's going to petition for it.

CORNELIUS
Tell her to get the signatures in order first. And say "orderly." Five times.

Marc laughs. Cornelius smiles in the lamplight.

CORNELIUS
Go to bed, son. Day two tomorrow.

MARC (V.O.)
Day two.

CORNELIUS
And Marc.

MARC (V.O.)
Yeah?

CORNELIUS
You stayed on the line.

MARC (V.O.)
So did you.

Click.

In the Oval Office, the President hangs up. Looks around the room. The Lincoln portrait. The Chisholm photograph. The twins' card on the credenza. The Resolute Desk.

He gets up. Walks to the window. Looks out at the South Lawn in the dark. The Washington Monument, lit white against a black, freezing sky.

Then he turns, looks at the couch in the middle of the Oval Office, the one where every President has sat across from prime ministers and kings.

He takes off his shoes.

Agent Okonjo, standing post just outside the door to the Rose Garden colonnade, sees him through the glass. Watches the President of the United States climb up and stand on the Oval Office couch in his socks, alone, at 11:46 PM, both arms raised to nobody.

She keeps her face perfectly professional.

She says nothing.

She will never tell anyone. She will tell her own daughter, once, thirty years from now.

SMASH TO BLACK.

SUPER: END OF CHAPTER TWELVE

CONTINUITY LEDGER — CHAPTER 12

Timeline: Sun Jan 5, 2025 → Tue Jan 21, 2025, 11:46 PM EST. **Inauguration: Mon Jan 20, 2025, 12:02 PM EST, Capitol Rotunda** (moved indoors for extreme cold, as in real life; first indoor inauguration since 1985; 22°F; flags at half-staff for President Carter). **First full day in office: Tue Jan 21, 2025.**

Ages (Jan 20–21, 2025): Marc 33 (turned 33 Sun Jan 5, 2025) · Esther 32 · **Amond 32** (33 on Feb 10) · Harmony 32 · Emma & Victoria 12 · Lyric 10 · Elxa 34 · Grace 30 · Tayia 32 · **Tyler 33 (Jan 4)** · Arianna 32 · Natasha 53 · Robert 55 · Victor 78 · Joan 76 · Odessa 96 · Cornelius 66 · Lorraine 63 · Neil 40 · Simone 37 · Patti 60 · Dante 43 · Roy 67 · Mae 65 · Gloria 58 · **Agent Ruth Okonjo 49 (b. Jan 2, 1976)** · Mrs. Ernestine Powell 79 (fictional, Altadena) · Rev. Calvin Holloway 70. Cabinet: Naledi 36 · Julian 37 · Jonah 37 · Darnell 35 · **Priya 35 (Jan 9)** · Theo 34 · Dre 36 · Rafael 32 · Omar 35 · Kai 29 · Mara Lindgren 37 · Ben Osei 34. Real people: Biden 82 · Harris 60 · Trump 78 · Chief Justice Roberts 69 · Justice Jackson 54 · Sheinbaum 62 · Trudeau 53 · Zelenskyy 46 · Speaker Johnson 52 · Jeffries 54 · Schumer 74 · Muir 51.

Real events depicted: the electoral count, Jan 6, 2025 (Harris presiding; 359–179 in our world); the LA wildfires from Jan 7 (Palisades and Eaton/Altadena); Jimmy Carter's state funeral at the National Cathedral, Jan 9 (died Dec 29, 2024, at 100); the Gaza ceasefire phase one, Jan 19, with the first three hostages released; the inauguration moved into the Rotunda and the parade moved to Capital One Arena; the National Prayer Service at the National Cathedral, Jan 21; Trudeau still PM (until Mar 2025); Sheinbaum President of Mexico.

Our-world events: Marc sworn in by Chief Justice Roberts on **Odessa's family Bible** (held by Esther, with the twins' names written in it by Odessa in 2012). Amond sworn in by Justice Jackson on Gloria Baker's Bible (held by Lyric). **Trump attends the inauguration.** Inaugural line: "Because we're their grandchildren." Marc walks two blocks on Pennsylvania Avenue (Agent Okonjo allowed one). Oval Office: a Lincoln portrait plus a Shirley Chisholm 1972 photograph; navy drapes; the twins' card on the credenza (lent by Cornelius: "Return it when you leave office. Eight years."). **EO 14148 (Clean Government / Ethics Commitments) signed Mon Jan 20, 8:49 PM EST**, including a stock-trading ban covering the President and VP; Marc signs with a bluebird (White House Counsel Ben Osei "checking"). Five inaugural balls; Marc dances with Odessa at the NMAAHC ball ("Don't you dare spin me"). Twins explore the White House (132 rooms; they bowl at 6:58 AM against Esther's "not before 7" rule; Agent Hollis on the residence door). The first PDB (Mara Lindgren; Marc sits on the floor): Gaza phase one fragile; Ukraine;

China "studious" in the Taiwan Strait (a seed for 2027 and 2032). **Naledi Asante-Brooks confirmed Jan 20, 81–17**; she flies to the Middle East Thu Jan 23. **Simone Smilley confirmed DHS Secretary Tue Jan 21, 74–25 (31 Republicans), sworn in 11:40 AM by Neil on Odessa's Bible.** Arianna's AG confirmation vote is Thu Jan 23; Julian Park's hearing is Wed Jan 22. National Prayer Service benediction by Rev. Holloway ("let him be standing for somebody who can't"). **Jan 21 signing, 2:01–3:12 PM EST, Oval Office; Lyric hands out the 12 engraved pens ("LET'S FIX IT"):** EO 14149 Orderly, Secure, Legal Immigration (Simone) · 14150 100-Day Peace Initiative (Naledi) · 14151 North American Partnership Commission (Omar) · 14152 American Sovereign Fund preparation (Julian) · 14153 Life-Saving Medicines (Jonah) · 14154 Ten Million Homes / federal land (Darnell) · 14155 Every Lead Pipe (the pen goes to a Flint mother, not to Kai Mahoe) · 14156 Clean Energy (Theo drops the pen) · 14157 National Council on Political Violence and Domestic Peace (Arianna) · 14158 No Veteran Waits (Dre; "Thank you for your service") · 14159 Puerto Rico Equality Task Force (Rafael: "Para La Perla") · **14160 Los Angeles Wildfire Recovery and Rebuilding (new, added after Altadena; the pen goes to Mrs. Ernestine Powell, 79, whose husband built their porch in 1974).** Lawsuits from Texas, Louisiana, and Florida against EO 14149. Foreign calls: Sheinbaum 3:41 PM, Trudeau 4:02 PM, **Zelenskyy 4:20 PM** (Elxa: "You absolutely scheduled it"). **Grace's first briefing, 4:47 PM** (the $8 Twitter line; the "family business" answer: "Wait until we've had a full week"). **Hakeem Jeffries is Speaker of the House** (elected Jan 3, 2025). Trump's dinner with Marc is set for February. Marc reads Biden's letter in the Resolute Desk (contents private), then calls Cornelius at 11:38 PM; both "stayed on the line." Marc stands on the Oval Office couch at 11:46 PM; Agent Okonjo witnesses it and tells no one. Twins and Lyric start Sidwell Mon Jan 27, 2025.

Bible 09 refinement: the "Day One" orders were signed across Jan 20 (EO 14148) and Jan 21 (EO 14149–14160), and EO 14160 (Wildfire Recovery) is added to the locked list.

Looming events (in-world): Sidwell, Mon Jan 27; Cabinet confirmations; the Stock Trading Ban in Congress; the Sovereign Fund 90-day blueprint (due ~Apr 21); the 100-day Peace Initiative (Day 100 is ~Apr 30, 2025); the Trump dinner in February; *Avengers: The Kang Dynasty* on May 2, 2025 (secret: Tyrese).